quote a newspaper editorial at the time, that the party, in these early days, was somewhat 'schizophrenic'.[18]

Clearly, this confusion over the RSS and its role needed to be resolved. Within a month of Advani's clear exposition on the BJP's unbreakable ties to the RSS, the party issued a policy statement which made it clear that it no longer seemed to 'want to or to be able to play down its Jana Sangh-RSS origins'.[19] Even as it reiterated its commitments to the beliefs of the JP movement and its new adage of 'Gandhian socialism', it declared that those who belong to 'social or cultural organisations … working for the uplift of the masses and not engaged in political activity' (read RSS) could join the new party. Further, it reiterated that membership of one would not repudiate membership of the other.[20] In short, the BJP came out 'openly in favour of "dual membership", the rock on which relations between the undivided Janata Party foundered'.[21]

While the BJP's decision to stand by its earlier belief in the innocuousness of 'dual membership' underscored its determination to not disown its Jan Sangh–RSS lineage, it also sought to harness and inherit the larger political legacy of the Janata Party. And so, in the party's first national plenary session in Bombay on 28–30 December 1980, Vajpayee declared that the BJP had embraced the 'samata' (equality) that B.R. Ambedkar had argued for. He also invoked a new notion of 'positive secularism'.[22] This, Vajpayee indicated, was akin to what was practised by the Maratha king Shivaji towards minorities in the seventeenth century: the Chhatrapati had a Muslim personal attendant during his Agra captivity and is also known to have launched his Konkan campaign in 1661 after seeking the blessings of the Muslim saint Yakutbaba of Kelshi (Ratnagiri).[23]

Later in the 1980s, L.K. Advani would redefine the political landscape with his charge that the Congress was 'pseudo-secular', but already in 1980, the BJP was arguing that it stood for a notion of secularism that embraced tolerance but not appeasement. It was at the time a small north Indian party still, and this early idea of 'positive secularism' was meant to blunt the criticism of those who saw the party's 'refusal to disown the Jan Sangh–RSS aspect of its heritage